

Psalms 130

Out of the Depths

Out of the depths have I cried unto thee, O Lord... for with the Lord there is mercy
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Out of the depths have I cried unto thee, O LORD.*
- 2 *Lord, hear my voice: let thine ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications.*
- 3 *If thou, LORD, shouldest mark iniquities, O Lord, who shall stand?*
- 4 *But there is forgiveness with thee, that thou mayest be feared.*
- 5 *I wait for the LORD, my soul doth wait, and in his word do I hope.*
- 6 *My soul waiteth for the Lord more than they that watch for the morning: I say, more than they that watch for the morning.*
- 7 *Let Israel hope in the LORD: for with the LORD there is mercy, and with him is plenteous redemption.*
- 8 *And he shall redeem Israel from all his iniquities.*

2 · CONTEXT

One of the traditional penitential psalms, Psalm 130 moves from a cry rising out of overwhelming depths, through honest acknowledgment that no one could stand if God kept a strict account of sin, into a description of patient, watchful waiting compared to a night watchman's longing for dawn, before widening into a call for all Israel to hope in the Lord's abundant mercy. Henry treats the psalm's central pivot—"but there is forgiveness with thee"—as the hinge on which the entire prayer turns, transforming an otherwise hopeless situation into grounds for confident waiting.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with a cry rising from genuine depths, addressed directly to the Lord, asking specifically that He hear the voice and attend to the supplications being made—urgency and directness marking the opening plea.

Verse 3-4

A sobering admission follows: if the Lord kept strict account of iniquities, no one could stand before Him. Yet the psalm's decisive turn arrives immediately after: but there is forgiveness with Him, so that He may be feared—reverence, remarkably, is grounded in mercy rather than only in dread.

Verse 5-6

Waiting is described with deliberate intensity: the psalmist waits for the Lord, the soul waits, and hope rests specifically in His word. The comparison sharpens further—waiting for the Lord more than watchmen wait for the morning, longing repeated for emphasis, picturing eyes fixed on the horizon through a long night.

Verse 7-8

The psalm closes by widening from personal experience to national hope: let Israel hope in the Lord, for with Him is mercy and abundant, plentiful redemption. The final promise is comprehensive—He will redeem Israel from all their iniquities, not merely some, closing the psalm exactly where its opening admission required: total forgiveness for a total need.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Honest acknowledgment that no one could stand before God on the basis of strict accounting does not lead to despair here but to a decisive pivot toward mercy, since forgiveness—not merit—is what actually grounds reverence for Him. Waiting for God, compared to a watchman's longing for dawn, is patient without being passive, sustained specifically by hope in His word rather than by any guarantee of an immediate answer.

Application for life today.

When you cry out from genuine depths, follow this psalm's pattern by naming the cry directly to God rather than letting despair remain unspoken. Let verse 4's pivot—"but there is forgiveness with thee"—interrupt any tendency to measure your standing before God by strict accounting of your own failures. Practice the kind of waiting described in verses 5–6, hope anchored specifically in God's word rather than in the absence of an answer, the way a watchman's hope is anchored in the certainty that morning will come.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What depth are you currently crying out from, and what would it mean to name that cry directly to God, as verse 1 models, rather than leaving it unspoken?

2. How does verse 4's pivot—'but there is forgiveness with thee'—interrupt a tendency to measure your standing before God by strict accounting of your own failures?

3. How does the watchman's certain hope for morning (vv. 5–6) model a kind of patient, word-anchored waiting you need in a situation where the answer has not yet come?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).